

become my reality. Reading these blogs was highly motivational and educational. Unfortunately, reading them also had unintended consequences. Three things happened that made me far less happy.

First, as my knowledge of investing and tax planning grew, I couldn't help but continue to glance in the rearview mirror, where I would see all the past blunders we made when we'd followed conventional wisdom and mainstream advice. Our investing mistakes were particularly painful because we paid an advisor handsomely for awful guidance. I spent a lot of time looking back with regret and bitterness.

Second, FIRE blogs put early retirement on a pedestal, so in my mind, early retirement became a nirvana. I felt the need to retire early. *Then* I could be happy. I stopped appreciating all the amazing things that I already had in my life. I lost the ability to be the carefree, happy-go-lucky person I used to be. Between glancing back at our past mistakes and looking forward to early retirement, I found myself unable to enjoy the present.

Third, while gaining a deeper understanding of our finances was initially a positive thing, I became overly focused on money. I focused on getting our expenses as low as possible so I could retire as soon as possible. I began to scrutinize every dollar that left our